

Introduction to Digital Humanities Group 5: Project management plan

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1 Project scope

The scope of this project is the cleaning of data from the British Library in order to conduct analyses on the dataset. The cleaning part of the project will consist of cleaning three columns on the entire dataset, that is, all sheets from the five Excel files. We motivate this by the fact that we all plan to work with a large amount of data to conduct our analyses, which are: (i) a linguistic analysis of titles (how title features connect to date and place of publishing, (ii) a match of Croatian publications, and (iii) a genre assignment to the works from the Unspecified file using machine learning based on book titles and genres from other files.

To conduct this work, we need to clean the Author column, the Title one, and the Imprint one. We will not spend time clearing other columns as they are irrelevant for the scope of our studies. Each member of the group will be assigned to work on a specific column, to avoid overlapping our cleaning operations.

2 Team roles and responsibilities

We decided to team up, Koji, Petar and Victor, because we share a common interest in computational and corpus linguistics. We would hence probably need similar data, which will facilitate our cleaning operations. We are also following the same courses, leading to a similar schedule and helping us to meet on a regular basis.

On October 28th, we held our first meeting to share our different project ideas and decide on the global management of the project and assign specific roles. Petar will oversee the general workflow, organize meetings, and facilitate communication; Victor will keep track of the principal milestones of the project; and Koji will handle the timeline and, consequently, the Gantt chart. We also decide to have some flexibility about our responsibilities, since we meet on a regular basis, which helps us to have almost daily catchups on our progress.

More specifically, for the cleaning phase, we think the best option is to assign a column per person: Victor will be in charge of the Imprint column, Koji of the Title one while Petar will clean the Author one. We also plan to keep track of our difficulties and methods to ensure collaboration within the cleaning phase of the project.

3 Tools

To carry out this project, we will make use of different tools. The data cleaning will be executed using OpenRefine. GitHub will serve as an online repository of the datasets (original and cleaned) but will also keep track of version control, ensure transparency of the project and enable reusability of the data (according to FAIR principles). It is also a safeguard to have our data stored there in addition to local storage. The internal communication will be handled via Microsoft 365, and particularly OneNote, where we will consistently publish our progress, issues, and questions. Excel will be used for the creation and update of the Gantt Chart. For daily and quick communication, WhatsApp will be used. Its main purpose is to easily arrange meetings, notify all collaborators that something was posted on one of the other platforms and send quick or minor updates.

4 Work breakdown structure

We divide the work into five phases and plan to have continuous feedback on the milestones. We also plan two meetings regarding the workflow, each related to a transition between the main phases, to assess the work already done, discuss our concerns, and plan the following phase.

The first phase consists of familiarization with OpenRefine, the dataset and other tools we will employ. This preparatory work is needed to perform in a high-quality and smooth way the rest of the project. This step is necessary to make any specific and serious decisions about the rest of the work plan, as we have to get a sense of what is feasible and what isn't.

After this preliminary stage, we will have our first meeting about starting to effectively clean our dataset. We will decide how to process, discuss the technical details and agree on an order of operations compatible with our personal availabilities.

The third phase will be reconciling these columns with Wikidata. Once again, we will determine the technical aspects and timeframe over the course of the project.

In the fourth phase, after having a second meeting in which we will discuss the outcomes of the cleaning and the final steps of our project, we will try to assess the quality of the original dataset on the one hand, and the quality of our cleaning on the other hand. Petar volunteers to supervise this task.

The fifth and last phase will consist of the writing of the final version of the report. We decide that Petar will oversee the Data Assignment Report, Victor the Project Management one and Koji the Gantt chart.

5 Timelines and milestones

The initial timeline aims for the completion of the data cleaning by December 1st, while the deadline for the broader project is on January 5th. We choose an early date on purpose, to allow time for adaptation in case of unforeseeable issues (see the risk section of the report). The principal milestones were discussed in the sections above and can be consulted in the Gantt chart.

6 Risk assessment

We identify three potential risks that we have to take into account. The first one concerns the risk of delay caused by an illness or absence of one or several members. That's why we choose an early date for the data cleaning, to contain and mitigate this risk in case it occurs. The second one is losing our data or intermediary work. To mitigate this one, we use online repositories such as GitHub and Microsoft 365, as well as local backups on our own computers. Lastly, we're keeping in mind the fact that we all come from different countries, speaking different languages, which can also hinder our communication or the way we're conceptualizing some aspects of the work.